

tools and techniques to fight the COVID-19 pandemic.

COVIDathon is a hackathon being conducted by the Decentralized AI Alliance and its partners SingularityNet and Ocean Protocol. The eight-week online hackathon aims at bringing AI enthusiasts and experts together on a single platform to build AI tools that will help in containing and managing the COVID-19 pandemic.

The role of AI and FOSS in preventing and containing pandemics in the future

As far as the prevention of a pandemic is concerned, a major lesson that the COVID-19 outbreak has taught us is to never underestimate the speed with which a contagious disease can spread. COVID-19 has disproved all predictions about the number of people it would infect, bringing entire countries to a halt and battering the global economy in the process. Speed is everything when it comes to preventing epidemics and pandemics. In the age of Big Data, only relying on statistics provided by government officials is no longer an option. Only sentient machines powered by AI have the required capability to scour through massive amounts of unstructured data across multiple mediums on the Internet to reach a prediction fast enough to prevent an epidemic. Therefore, it is beyond a doubt, that AI will play a major role in preventing the spread of diseases in the future.

There are two major challenges that we face in containing a contagious disease after it spreads. The first major challenge is social distancing. While social distancing can be voluntarily done to a certain extent, activities such as grocery shopping and making runs for essential supplies, force a person to come into contact with infected individuals. AI powered drone

technologies can be a major asset in this regard. Automating the collection and delivery of essential supplies using drones can make social distancing truly effective for people, especially when we are faced with lockdowns and curfews. It will also help in preventing the unnecessary hoarding of goods done by certain individuals during times of crisis, thus reducing shortages of key supplies.

The second major challenge is that members of the medical community are forced to come into contact with infected individuals during a pandemic, thus risking their lives and the lives of their families in the process. Major strides are currently being made in the field of robotics to remedy this problem. However, in future, more effort and funding will be required for building sentient robots that are able to provide at least the basic medical care to the patients, such as checking their vital parameters, taking basic

tests, performing diagnosis and cleaning the premises. This will reduce the risk to doctors and the hospital staff as well as help with containing the disease.

I would like to conclude this article by saying that epidemics and pandemics affect us all. It is not the problem of *some* but the problem of *everyone*. This requires us all to pitch in and make an effort in preventing and containing such outbreaks. It is a matter of great importance that the open source community makes an effort in furthering the research and development of the AI technologies that will prevent such a situation from occurring again in the future. The beauty of open source is that it not only gives everyone access to pitch in, but also provides everyone with the freedom to use the technology for free. In the under-developed and developing countries, such technologies can be crucial in saving the lives of millions of people. **END** 

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By: Mir H.S. Quadri

The author is a scholar and researcher in the fields of artificial intelligence and machine learning. He shares a deep love for Web development and has worked on multiple projects using a wide array of frameworks. He is also a FOSS enthusiast and actively contributes to several open source projects. You can find his works on codelatte.site.